> we mentally dismissed all the stolen property as an illusion or a bad dream . . . After these repeated betrayals, we entertained no further hopes of any help coming from these monsters. But given that our womenfolk and our honour were held hostage in Lahore, we had to submit, though sick at heart. We spent the next five months under the strictest surveillance, which was vexatious in the extreme: like clothes too tight in the heat. The feet of resilience stubbed toes on the rocks of oppression, but we could only beat our breasts to relieve the painful heart.[8]

Shah Shuja was not, however, the sort of man who would tolerate being detained at someone else's pleasure, and before long he had come up with an escape plan. His first action, as after his defeat, was to ensure the safety of his womenfolk, and before escaping himself he decided to smuggle his harem out of Lahore. This he did with the help of a Pashtun horse dealer and the Lahori traders who came to sell his women their groceries. According to traditions collected in the later *Siraj ul-Tawarikh*,

> He secretly purchased a number of horse-drawn wagons through some Indian women whom he had met because it was the custom in the homes of the great for them to come and go with goods for sale. In four trips, transporting ten persons at a time, the women left the city dressed in the clothes of Hindu women as if they were either going to swim in the river, as is the custom of the Hindus, or else to have an outing in the countryside. His retainers delivered his wives to Ludhiana, just over the border of the Company's territories, as he had ordered.[9]

When Ranjit Singh heard that Wa'fa Begum and the other women had made their escape, 'he bit the finger of astonishment with the teeth of regret' and increased the number of guards to 4,000, 'infesting every alley in the city, guarding all gates, all the mansions, even kitchens and lavatories, and especially our sleeping quarters . . . The soldiers would heat up oil and threaten torture, saying: "Give us your jewels, or else you'll feel the heat of this boiling oil!"' On a whim they would place Shuja in an iron cage installed in the courtyard. 'Wherever I went, even to do my ablutions, they would watch me. The world was becoming narrower for me and my household, and we soon became tired of observing the activities of these ill-educated and low-born Sikh people.' The Shah and his household took to reciting the verse from the Quran 'Deliver us from the tribe of the oppressors'.

> In answer to our midnight cries of despair, the following idea came as guidance: immediately below the chamber where we slept at night was the royal wardrobe, the quarters of faithful royal servants. We instructed them to make a hole in the ceiling of the lower chamber right under the bed, otherwise the guards would have noticed, and to dig a tunnel from the lower chamber